

Separation of presentation from application logic

One of the major downfalls of most web applications is the tight coupling of user interface elements with client application logic. This poses a significant problem in team environments because the skills required to develop these two parts are often satisfied by different people.

XUL provides a clear separation between the client application definition and programmatic logic ("content" consisting of XUL, XBL and JavaScript), presentation ("skin" consisting of CSS and images) and language-specific text labels ("locale" consisting of DTDs and string bundles in .properties files). The layout and appearance of XUL applications can be altered independently of the application definition and logic. Further, the application can be localised for different languages and regions independently of its logic or presentation.

This degree of separation results in applications that are easier to maintain by programmers and readily customisable by designers and language translators. The work flow of these interdependent activities is more easily co-ordinated than with HTML-based web applications, with less impact on the overall stability and quality of the system.

Easy customisation, localisation, or branding

Another highly practical benefit of the separation that XUL provides among application logic, presentation and language text is the ease of customising for different customers or groups of users.

A developer can maintain one primary code base for his application and customise the logo and branding for each of his customers by supplying different skins. An application that's written and deployed with an English language user interface can be translated to French for the same customer. While such changes are extensive and affect most (if not all) of the application, they're also isolated from one another enabling the core XUL definition and application logic to be shared among all of the custom versions.